

Central Asia and Afghanistan

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Astana, Kazakhstan: City of the Twenty-First Century?

Traveling over the steppes of Kazakhstan, a visitor might be forgiven for thinking that the steppe grasslands would simply go on forever with no hint of change. However, over the past decade there has arisen the “only city of the twenty-first century” according to Kazakhstan President Nursultan Nazarbayev. After independence from the U.S.S.R., President Nazarbayev unilaterally decided to move the capital from Almaty, a city he cited as too near the Chinese border and in a tectonically active area. He wanted the new capital to be more centrally located in Kazakhstan and renamed the northern city of Aqmola “Astana,” or “capital” in the Kazakh language.

President Nazarbayev then began to pour expansive revenues from oil and gas sales into building his grand new capital. No expense was spared and famous architects from Norman Foster to Manfredi Nicoletti created large and often whimsical buildings along the city’s main thoroughfare that links the new Presidential Palace (seven times the square footage of the White House) to Foster’s Khan Shatyr Entertainment Center, shaped like a collapsing tent. These two signature monuments along with others, like the pyramid-shaped “Palace of Peace and Reconciliation,” the new Kazakh museum (based on the Parthenon in Athens), and the Kaz Munai Gaz Complex (built on a plan similar to that of the Hotel Atlantis in the Bahamas) are interspersed between quickly constructed high-rise buildings by Chinese firms that are already starting to show signs of wear and deterioration. Most of the new residents of Astana have embraced this city as the new brash and brassy emblem of their country and hope that the world will come to know Kazakhstan because of cutting-edge architecture and bold city planning, and not as the home of the fictional character, Borat.





Read & Learn

- Explain the central role played by Central Asia and Afghanistan in the historic culture and economy of the Eurasian landmass.
- Express the importance of river valleys within the context of Central Asia and Afghanistan's population and economy.
- Indicate why the Aral Sea has shrunk dramatically and assess what might be done to reverse this process.
- Describe how Central Asian urban spaces are and are not changing.
- Show how economic development without proper attention to its effect on the environment can provide useful lessons to help improve future development policy.
- Identify the reasons why so many rural Tajik men must migrate to Russia to earn a living and discuss the effect that migration is having on village life.
- Portray the plight of Afghan farmers and explain why they find it difficult to stop growing poppies for opium.

▲ The landscape of Astana, Kazakhstan's capital, is changing quickly and dramatically with landmark buildings such as the Aq Orda ("white horde") Presidential Palace at the center of the photo and the twin golden towers of the House of Ministries, which harken back to pre-Soviet Muslim architecture in Central Asia.

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6 Central Asia and Afghanistan



Figure 6-0 The major physical features and countries of Central Asia and Afghanistan.

From 1920 to 1991, the Central Asian countries of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan were part of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (U.S.S.R.). The U.S.S.R. was a major international political player in the 1900s and the counterpart to the United States during the Cold War in the second half of the twentieth century. As such, the area was viewed as a part of a superpower and grouped with the “developed” world along with the other Soviet republics, such as Russia and Ukraine. That Central Asia was not as advanced as the Slavic areas of the U.S.S.R. was not widely acknowledged until after the fall of the U.S.S.R. and the independence of the five countries in 1991. Since then, Central Asia has had a more difficult time adjusting to independent status and to the difficult economic changes than any other region of the former U.S.S.R. These countries have shown economic renewal in the twenty-first century, but exhibit both authoritarianism and chaos politically.

Prior to the Soviet period, the region was more closely tied to southern and western Asia because of the Islamic heritage it shares with the Middle East and western South Asia. Afghanistan has been an independent country since the nineteenth century, but had close trade and cultural ties with the region absorbed by the U.S.S.R. The region’s cultural history has been dominated by two linguistic groups that include various ethnic groups of Persian and Turkic origins. As a linguistic case in point, all six countries in this region have the same suffix, “-istan,” which is old Persian for “place of.” Tajikistan, for example, means “place of the Tajiks.” These cultural ties link many groups and cross the borders that would eventually separate Afghanistan from the other five countries. Half of the Tajiks live in Afghanistan and the other half in Tajikistan and Uzbekistan. Significant minorities of Uzbeks and Turkmen also live in Afghanistan. For historic, linguistic, and cultural reasons, Afghanistan is included in this chapter (see chapter opener map).

Central Asia and Afghanistan connect four of the world’s great “realms”: Russia, and through it Europe; the Middle East and North Africa; South Asia; and East Asia. This world region was at the crossroads of some of the most important ancient empires, such as Mesopotamia (in modern Iraq), the Indus River valley (now in Pakistan), the Iranian Plateau, Greece, Rome, and China. This very centrality gives Central Asia both its name and its place in history and geography, and its strategic significance ensures the region’s pivotal role in many political and economic issues the world faces today.

Central Asia’s and Afghanistan’s Environmental and Historical Contexts

The contemporary scene in Central Asia and Afghanistan cannot be appreciated without considering the natural and human contexts of the region. The seeming paucity of natural resources sharply

contrasts with a rich diversity of cultural groups, often complexly intermixed and established in place for centuries if not millennia. The rhythmic ebb and flow of nature and society provide a framework that profoundly influences present patterns of economic and political development.

Environmental Setting: A Challenging Locale

The area of Central Asia and Afghanistan crosses latitudes equal to the distance between Austin, Texas and Edmonton, Alberta in Canada, and roughly three-quarters the longitudinal distance of the continental United States (Figure 6-1). Despite this large area, the region is sparsely populated, ranging from a low of 15 people per square mile (6 per square kilometer) in Kazakhstan to 173 people per square mile (67 per square kilometer) in Uzbekistan. This is attributable in part to the natural setting, which encompasses many landform areas but only four natural regions (Figure 6-2). The region is dominated by mountain climates in the southeast and deserts and midlatitude steppes in lower-lying areas to the north and west.

Landforms

With soaring mountain peaks over 19,700 feet (6,000 meters) high and depressions that sink below sea level, Central Asian landscapes are extremely varied. Extensive lowland deserts and semiarid plains contrast with intensive islands of verdant vegetation in deep river valleys and narrow floodplains, creating a difficult, often extreme, setting for human life and livelihood.

Like the Himalayas to the east, the tectonic upthrust caused by the Indian plate sliding under the Eurasian plate created the mountainous region of Central Asia. Due to continuing tectonic activity in the region, Central Asia and Afghanistan are prone to frequent earthquakes. The major mountain chains are the **Hindu Kush** (in Afghanistan), the **Pamirs** (in Tajikistan and Afghanistan), the Fan



▲ **Figure 6-1 Central Asia and Afghanistan.** A size and locational comparison with the conterminous United States and Canada shows how large the central Asian region actually is.